

THE WORLD'S SEXIEST SPELLBINDERS

Rare are those gifted with the magnetism capable of attracting passionate followers. KEITH DUNSTAN reports on some who succeeded.

THERE are certain people who have the gift, the art, of casting a spell through sheer mass hypnotism — call them spellbinders. The first I encountered was the Reverend Dr Robert Schuller at the Crystal Cathedral. The Crystal Cathedral, built by Bob Schuller, was just one freeway turn-off past Disneyland in California. In terms of sheer wonder the Cathedral had the edge even on Tomorrowland. It was made of tubular steel like a gigantic rotary clothes hoist but walls, foyer, ceiling, everything was made of glass. And it was bigger than the Cathedral of Notre Dame.

Now Robert Schuller had one of the world's finest pipe organs, he had a choir of 120, beautifully robed, and he always had a great star to sing such as Beverly Sills from the Metropolitan Opera. Down the nave of the cathedral there were 12 fountains representing the 12 apostles and at deep emotional moments they would throw jets into the air.

Schuller would start talking softly but his voice would rise in passion. Then suddenly a whole wall would open. Great doors, 20 metres high, pushed out by hydraulic rams, would move. Robert Schuller would stride out to the open space, throw up his arms to the heavens above and the result couldn't be more dramatic. Clearly he was talking directly to God.

I was reminded of Robert Schuller when I heard of the arrest in North Carolina of Bhagwan Shree Rajneesh. The Baghwan, meaning Blissful One, had this same sense of magic. He had 500,000 followers around the world and he had installed his own little mecca, Rajneeshpuram in Oregon.

Publicity was no problem. He was so extraordinary every Australian correspondent in the US went to see him. Before the audience, you had to be

washed and purified. You were not permitted to wear any wool and the Baghwan was in a room cooled to eight degrees. He mustn't be contaminated. And, of course, he looked perfect: long saintly silk robes, a beanie, sandals, a grey beard a metre long and enormous eyes like puddles.

If a modern Cecil B. de Mille was looking for a man to play Moses the Baghwan was the man.

He claimed to be the world's greatest lover. Could he be taken seriously? And yet it was extraordinary to observe the passion of his followers, the happiness in their eyes as they clapped and chanted to his words.

The world is filled with the lonely, the uncertain, the worried and he was providing them with something.

We had our own spellbinder in King O'Malley, one of the architects of Federation and founder of the Commonwealth Bank. There was some mystery about his origins but he grew up in the US and as a young man in Texas he launched his own church which had the extraordinary name of the Waterlily Rockbound Church — the Red Skin Temple of the Cayuse Nation. He wanted to attract both whites and Indians and his church was based on brotherly love and the danger of those twin demons, drink and tobacco.

He thought it necessary to have lots of miracles. He had a disciple named Mr Angel. He used to send Angel off into the mountains and at the appropriate moment, when Bishop O'Malley was telling his congregation that greed and sin would be their downfall, a great flame would burst on the mountain top, a sign from the Almighty.

Also up there on that mountain Mr Angel found some sacred tablets, on which were etched in a strange tongue the rules of the Waterlily Church. All would have been fine had not Mr Angel ratted on him and spilled the news. King O'Malley knew he was ruined when he read the headlines in a paper: King O'Malley's Angel found drunk in Denver. So O'Malley fled to Australia to become a politician and never quite lost his evangelist touch. He would open a meeting with words like this: "Brothers, sisters, fellow Christians. I don't see any



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profiteers, racketeers, or gilt-spurred Brahma-pootra roosters in this meeting."

Unquestionably O'Malley was inspired by Joseph Smith, founder of the Mormon Church. Smith was led by an angel to a spot where he found golden tablets with messages for his church written in ancient hieroglyphics. Now the Mormon Church is one of the greatest in America and its most recent fascinating exercise is this attempt to trace the name of every human who ever lived.

Mormons are searching the registries, the birth certificates, the parish records of every nation who will receive them. The names are all stored on microfilm in nuclear bomb-proof vaults in Utah. The theory is that devotees can have their ancestors brought back to God retrospectively.

The great ones all have this personal magnetism. Back in the 1960s the Beatles became disciples of His Holiness Maharishi Yogi. They went to see him in the snowy foothills of the Himalayas. Now his practising followers are said to include American actors Clint Eastwood and Burt Reynolds, the former US Davis Cup captain Arthur Ashe, the Beach Boys pop group and Doug Henning, a magician.

The Maharishi has the Age of Enlightenment Company, said to be worth \$150 million. He has his own private jet, a Boeing 727, a personal helicopter, a fleet of limousines, a Rolls-Royce and a stretched Cadillac. According to his press releases if he can manage to get more than the square root of one per cent of the world's population meditating together Utopia might be everlasting... "it will produce a wave of harmony and happiness throughout the world."

The spellbinders seem to have these essential ingredients: wonderful thespian skills, an air of mystery and a goodly flow of money. One of the most mysterious was Gurdjieff. He had a shaved skull like Yul Brynner, a great black moustache like Henry Lawson and awesome eyes as deep as tunnels. He was born in Russia and legend had it that he spent his youth in a relentless pilgrimage hunting for the meaning of life, through the Middle East, through all the holy places, India up to Lhasa in Tibet. He was shot and nigh mortally wounded three times.

He was a sorcerer and a magician and he understood transcendental meditation long before the Maharishi. He once said: "By only a few hours of self-preparation I could from a distance of tens of miles kill a yak; or, in 24 hours, could accumulate life forces of such compactness that I could in five minutes put to sleep an elephant."

In 1922 he set up court at the Chateau of Avon near Fontainebleau in France, ▽

